

Interviewer: Yes, good afternoon again. Hello, welcome.

Speaker: Greetings.

Interviewer: Thank you again very much for taking part in the interview. As we mentioned in our message, we would like to learn more about your views on romantic relationships. And we believe that your experience and perspective will be a great contribution to the project. Before we start, let me ask you again, is it okay for me to record this interview? We will only use this recording for transcription and note taking.

Speaker: It's fine with me.

Interviewer: It's all right. How old are you?

Speaker: [26-30].

Interviewer: How long have you been with your partner?

Speaker: [6-10].

Interviewer: Do you have children?

Speaker: No.

Interviewer: And who do you live with at home?

Speaker: I live with my mom.

Interviewer: What is your main source of income and what is your current job?

Speaker: I'm a [Job Title]. So I give [Service].

Interviewer: So, how would you like me to address your partner? Boyfriend, husband, lover, partner, you prefer.

Speaker: You can call them partners.

Interviewer: Can you tell me the story of meeting your partner and how your relationship started?

Speaker: Of course. [6-10] years ago, [6-10] years ago to be more precise, we were volunteering in the same community. We met in the university community. After that it became more of a flirtation.

Interviewer: I would be very grateful if I could get a little bit more detail from you about how your relationship has developed, if it is actually convenient for you.

Speaker: We were in the community together, and then his role started to increase. Along with his duties, my duties started to increase and we started to meet more often. We were meeting as a community, first as a group of friends. Then, I would like to get your opinion about something he wrote to me. That's how we started to meet together as a duo. Then our communication started to increase. It started to become more flirtatious, but this transition was not like that. Let's say it progressed in a more uncertain way.

Interviewer: And how would you rate the quality of your own relationship with your partner compared to the quality of your friends' relationships?

Speaker: Is it like a rating like this?

Interviewer: I mean, frankly, however you want to compare it. I don't want to direct you too much in this regard.

Speaker: Friends... I can say the same with the relationships around me.

Interviewer: Would you like to explain a little bit more why you say that?

Speaker: Of course, I have married friends around me, I have friends who are normal lovers for a long time. In general, they have a healthy relationship, they are progressing. They have such goals, they work towards these goals. Of course, there are rough problems in their relationship, but they can solve them together. So I think it's the same.

Interviewer: And you think you're like that. And may I ask how many romantic relationships you've had in the past?

Speaker: It's never happened before. My first partner.

Interviewer: What makes a relationship high quality for you?

Speaker: Having a love connection, of course. In addition to that, you can actually talk and spend time together and not get bored. But it's not that I'm going to spend time together all the time. I can say spending time with everyone having their own private space together. In addition to this, when a problem arises, when a problem arises between two people, to be able to talk about it together and to be able to continue it without running away from the discussion.

Interviewer: Would you like to elaborate a little bit more on why you say that?

Speaker: In every relationship, there are situations where two people disagree or think differently. In such cases, it is also unhealthy for one of them to take it on the chin without saying anything. Or it is also unhealthy for someone to impose completely. Two people should be able to come together and talk and discuss to find a common solution. Maybe this should be done in a calmer tone.

Interviewer: So what are the things that make a relationship low quality for you?

Speaker: Limiting each other may be what makes the relationship low quality. So narrowing the space of freedom. In other words, maybe imposing their own rules accordingly. And maybe I can also say. Especially giving mixed signals. Also based on this. Giving mixed signals about what it wants, what direction it wants to move in. Does he want to continue, does he want not to continue? When these come together, I think he thinks about the quality of the relationship. Because the other side is not sure about the relationship.

Interviewer: So would you say that high quality relationships are those that do not limit each other, where private space is respected?

Speaker: I can tell you.

Interviewer: So how can a person know that they are in such a relationship? Can you tell us more about that?

Speaker: Isn't it a recognition that it is associated with high quality?

Interviewer: Yes, you can answer for high quality. And you can also answer on the basis of these qualifiers that you are obviously using. You mentioned a relationship, a communication, in the same way that our communication is healthy and the space is not restricted. For example, how can he know that he is in such a relationship?

Speaker: Maybe by putting his own feelings and looking at them. What feelings are there? For example, does he feel anger all the time in a relationship, does he feel that his needs are not being seen? Actually, by monitoring oneself, one can understand what kind of relationship one is in. If he/she is constantly experiencing negative emotions, it may mean that the relationship is not good for him/her and maybe damaging. On the contrary, if there are no negative feelings and thoughts, if he is in a very satisfying relationship, he realizes that he is in a relationship of the highest quality.

Interviewer: So when would you say your relationship has become more limiting and when has it been the least?

Speaker: I'm not in a very limiting relationship, so I can't say it happened. I think it's another problem that it's not so limited. So I don't have a limiting partner. But this is also a problem. I think it's a problem when everything is on the edge.

Interviewer: So what are the most important things for you in a relationship? You touched on it a little bit before, but I'd like to ask you again if it's appropriate.

Speaker: The most important things... To feel safe throughout the relationship. And also to feel that when you share something, it will be valued, it will be listened to. And to be thought of. It can be any thought. It can be a subtle thought, it can be a very simple "maybe the sea would like this". Can I add anything else? The most important things I give... Respect in any way. That everything goes within the boundaries of respect. And feeling safe.

Interviewer: Would you like to explain a little bit more why you say that?

Speaker: Which one should I open?

Interviewer: So you can talk about all of them, why you say these concepts are obviously the most important things. Or whichever one you want to talk about. You mentioned that it is important to feel safe, to feel valued, to be listened to, to be thought about, to be respected, to be respected. I would like to know a little bit more about why these things are important to you.

Speaker: Especially in a long-lasting relationship, for it to be sustainable, for example, it is very important to feel safe. Because when you feel insecure, I think both your own psychology is affected and your relationship, that is, the situation towards your partner is also affected. And even if there is no insecurity, I'm talking about something that depends on feeling. It means that something is not going well. For example, when we look at it in such a way that we want this relationship to last, to last a long time. In addition to that, I think respect is also very important. A person should protect their integrity in a relationship. In order to protect this, they need to be free from many forms of violence, including psychological violence, so that they can respect their own self and move forward. I can explain it like this.

Interviewer: What is love for you?

Speaker: For me love is...a biological process. I don't think it's to be trusted. It's a feeling. It can be a lot of things, so it can be very misleading. Especially when it reminds you of things from the past. The biological mechanism from the past... I see it as something misleading because it may be formed based on all kinds of familiar events. Especially someone who feels very high should be treated more cautiously. Let me summarize it like this without doing too much. It's a biological feeling. I mean like every emotion. I should say that it is a feeling that needs to be careful because it comes from the past, so maybe it does not deserve the importance given by society. Especially for a relationship. Because of the thing, I mean. "You have to fall in love", "A relationship cannot be sustained without falling in love", you know, from the very familiar social media. Because of the things that come from movies, TV series, popular culture. It is a more instantaneous, short-term feeling.

Interviewer: You mentioned it, you touched on it a little bit, but I would like to ask you again. How important is love in a relationship?

Speaker: I mean, I don't think it's a big deal. It might be good to get it started. At a certain point, it may not necessarily indicate a dangerous situation for every person. Someone who is more securely attached will fall in love with someone who is more securely attached, for example, it will be much more useful for him. Therefore, I see it as something that should be cautious and should not be given too much importance.

Interviewer: How do you know if your partner loves you?

Speaker: So verbal expressions are important for me. It is important that he/she expresses it verbally. In addition to that, it is a criterion that he/she can not only verbalize it but also show it in behavior. I don't usually demand too much for this behavior. I said that at the beginning and in the relationship, to think about more subtle things. Of course, this is in my head, but I can concretize such an issue by giving an example. I mean, she might buy something that I would like. Or on the way home, "the sea was sick today", an orange, I mean, these very small things that don't matter at all, maybe she should show them, think about them in advance.

Interviewer: What would you say are the challenges in your relationship?

Speaker: We can disagree on some points, even if it's very small, and my partner prefers to proceed in his own way. Or he proceeds in a more maverick way, for example when I say something. He says, "No, this is not the way to do it, this is how I do it". I think this might be the biggest challenge in our relationship. He takes decisions more on his own initiative.

Interviewer: Do you and your partner fight?

Speaker: We do. The frequency varies like this. My partner is not someone who brings a lot of things, that is, an argument, something he is uncomfortable with. I usually start the fights by telling the points I am uncomfortable with.

Interviewer: You said it varies in frequency. How often do these fights usually happen?

Speaker: I think it happens every two or three months. Right now, there are months when it doesn't happen. Every 2-3 months on average.

Interviewer: And what are these fights about?

Speaker: Fights...I think we usually have problems with information transfer, that's why it happens. This information transfer is about what my partner does. When he shares what he does, he may not say it very clearly and this creates a problem. It's like he hesitates to give all the information. He probably doesn't hesitate, but he probably doesn't want to share. Arguments usually arise because of this. I am in favor of being more open and sharing everything.

Interviewer: So how do you resolve these fights?

Speaker: I can solve fights by talking for hours. My partner probably complains about this. It goes like this. I don't like to leave a conversation without closing something I'm uncomfortable with and maybe I explain the situation. Therefore, in the end, I feel like this, I think like this, what do you actually feel, what do you think? How can we meet in the middle in a compromising attitude? It ends with a search for a solution somewhere. These searches for solutions do not always lead us to a solution. I mean sometimes it doesn't work, sometimes it does. But that moment is the point that ends the discussion.

Interviewer: So, apart from talking about these problems, apart from talking in general, what are other ways to maintain your relationship?

Speaker: Again from a perspective that debates are like fights.

Interviewer: So maintaining your overall relationship.

Speaker: Except verbally. We are in a long distance relationship right now. That's why it's usually through talking. Before that, I mean, you can spend time together, other than talking. We study, we watch something. We do activities or something, that's how we spend time.

Interviewer: Can you explain a little bit more about spending time? Can you give some more examples?

Speaker: I mean, we usually spend a lot of time studying together, a lot of time talking. Afterwards, we said studying. We watch more movies, movies, TV series together and spend time together. Sometimes we cook. I can add this too. Like this.

Interviewer: And would you say that this relationship is good for you?

Speaker: I will tell you.

Interviewer: Why?

Speaker: It's a difficult question. I mean, maybe for the reasons I mentioned at the beginning. So you have a good communication, apart from the arguments, in a good way. I apologize very much. I'll just be a second.

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Interviewer: Yes. [Laughs] Yeah. Last time we were at the point where you mentioned that this relationship was good for you and you were talking about exactly why it was good for you.

Speaker: The reason why I think this relationship is good for me is because I feel good in it and I actually want to continue. I can say that I don't have a binding reason to continue, that is, I don't want to continue the relationship without, for example, marriage or children.

Interviewer: So can you give concrete examples of when you feel good?

Speaker: Well, I mean, I like to spend time with my partner, I have fun with him, maybe I can say them, spending time together. So I feel good... I mean, when I do something, I don't want to do it with him/her, I don't want to tell him/her when I get good news or I want him/her to be one of the first people I call when I get bad news. I can't think of anything else right now.

Interviewer: And has this relationship changed you?

Speaker: He must have changed. Because I was [16-20] when I started the relationship. I'm [26-30] now. Together, I think it was a process in which we grew up together. I've become a little more sculpted. I mean, let me explain sculpting like this. I think it turned from a clearer person with sharp edges to a more vague and curved kind of relationship where those boundaries are more curved. Let me explain it this way, I was thinking more rigidly about relationships, about how they should be. I had harder boundaries. Now I have more, more boundaries... let me give you an example. I mean, I don't like my partner spending time with someone else at home at night, let's say with someone of the opposite sex. I probably wouldn't like it if it wasn't in a relationship. Right now, I can say that it's a pretty okay thing for me. Other...Can I add something else to this question? I would probably be more academic, I think I would be more social. When I started the relationship, most of my attention shifted to the relationship. Before, I was more social, more active and more obsessive about my studies. Fifty percent of my attention shifted to my relationship. That's why there may be such a change.

Interviewer: And do you think your partner changed during that relationship?

Speaker: I can say that while he had much more vague boundaries, that is, he didn't see a problem with anything he did, I think he started to get a boundary. Especially, how can there be other changes? He is also a very obsessive person about studies. I mean, he is more academically obsessed than me. Maybe he loosened up a bit there too. Probably not only because of me, of course.

Interviewer: I'm actually going to ask a similar question again. Is the person you were before the relationship the same person you are now?

Speaker: No, but I think time has an effect, not only in terms of the relationship but also time. Because I was very young, so maybe it's not the same person.

Interviewer: I will ask the same question about your partner. Do you think he is the same now as he was before the relationship?

Speaker: I think he is, I mean, of course he has changed, but he is very similar. The first person I knew and the second person are very, very similar. Character, traits. I think there is not much change there. You know, certain characteristics have changed, but the character hasn't changed drastically, I mean, it's the same person, it just differs a little bit.

Interviewer: And do you feel safe in this relationship?

Speaker: I mean, I often feel it.

Interviewer: Can you explain what you mean exactly? You know, for when you feel it and when you don't feel it, maybe.

Speaker: I don't feel safe at all when things are not told to me clearly. And it becomes a problem for me. So I often, usually feel safe, but when I think that something is being hidden from me, let me say that that confidence diminishes. And suddenly I can find myself in a more insecure place.

Interviewer: Can you give an example of a time when you felt safe?

Speaker: I feel safe. I mean, of course, trust is like this. It is a trust for the continuation of the relationship, in other words, it is something about trust for the future. Especially because trust is a broad concept. I don't feel psychologically or physically insecure. It is more about the future. There is an insecurity about a question, about "I wonder if my partner wants to be with me?". I feel safe for the majority concept. The places where I feel insecure like this are more in discussion environments. I mean, every moment we spend together, when there are no arguments, I generally feel safe.

Interviewer: Now I also want to visualize the question I will ask you. So I will share the screen if it is convenient for you.

Speaker: It's appropriate.

Interviewer: Just a second. My computer is very slow. That's why I kept you waiting. Can you see it on the screen?

Speaker: Uh-huh, I see.

Interviewer: If I ask you "my partner usually really listens to me". Between options one and nine, which one would you choose?

Speaker: I think it's six. I don't think he really listens.

Interviewer: What if I ask, "My partner is usually sensitive to my needs?"

Speaker: Uh-huh. I think I'm going to give it a little low, but I want to give it a six.

Interviewer: Uh-huh. I'm stopping the feed. Sorry. Uh, yeah. Uh-huh. In our first question, I asked you "my partner usually really listens to me" and you answered six. I'm going to ask you why you think six is appropriate.

Speaker: Because when he is listening to me, he is thinking too many things in the background. And because he's thinking, he's probably not really listening to me. No, not probably, I mean he's not actually listening. There again, he understands what I say. But he doesn't deepen it in his mind.

Interviewer: Can you give me an example of this happening?

Speaker: Sure. Yeah. For example, let's say I share with him a stressful situation I'm going through, and I tell him every aspect of it. He seems to be listening, nodding and so on. But in the background, he may be thinking about the work he is going to do at work, for example, a task. He may be counting the men who will come to his carpet pitch in the evening. He's conducting various tests like this while he's listening. This is how I understand it. Then he sends a message to someone, for example. It's long or he takes out his notebook and takes a note. That's how I know that I wasn't actually listened to. He is thinking about something else in the background. I deducted points for that.

Interviewer: So why six and not five or seven?

Speaker: I mean, what was five? I think he was partially listening to me.

Interviewer: Five is partly true.

Speaker: I mean, it's not like he's not listening at all. But it's not at a seventh listening either. I mean, he listens at a very medium, average level. But I can't say that he partially listens. Sometimes he pays attention to those details, but let me put it this way. He doesn't listen to people the way I listen. What is listening? I mean, you don't just listen to him, you produce something, you ask questions. You concentrate on it. Since it's not like that, maybe it doesn't feel like listening to me. He just records that information. He listens, but he doesn't listen deeply.

Interviewer: Yes, one of the questions was "My partner is usually sensitive to my needs". And here you answered six. Actually, I'm going to ask the same thing. Why did you answer six here?

Speaker: So again, I can't say that he doesn't partially recognize my needs. Again, I mean, there are places he sees. I mean, he does something a little bit more, but he does something more. I mean, I gave six because I feel like it's not more. It does something more, but not more.

Interviewer: And can you give concrete examples on these?

Speaker: I mean, for example, I'm going to leave because I want to tell something. If I tell something, if I want to tell something, he listens there. Let me say he makes an effort to stay there. Especially when I have health problems, he usually acts quickly to meet those needs. When I need something, he goes and gets it immediately. I can say that. Other than that... I mean, he doesn't think too deeply in terms of needs. I mean, he catches them in a more physical place.

Interviewer: So why six and not five, or seven and not six?

Speaker: Here, it does one more click, one more click more of the shortening. But again, he does it without deepening it. In other words, it doesn't do it so strongly as to say seven.

Interviewer: Yes, I do. I hope you don't mind me asking, and if this is a sensitive subject for you to share, please feel free to say so. But I'd also like to know more about your physical intimacy as a couple if you'd like to answer if that's okay with you. How often do you have sexual intercourse these days?

Speaker: We can skip these questions.

Interviewer: It's done.

Speaker: Yes, I actually have another question, you know, "how satisfied are you with your sex life". You can decide for yourself. If you want to skip this question without answering it.

Interviewer: This is also very parallel, again we can skip it.

Speaker: It's done. Whatever you prefer.

Interviewer: I will share the screen again. How satisfied are you with your relationship in general?

Speaker: I mean, I'd say I'm very satisfied.

Interviewer: Uh-huh. Well, I will ask you about this satisfaction again in the form of a scale.

Speaker: I'm very pleased, where does it correspond...How many are there? 2, 3, 6, 7. It's a 7-point scale, 10. This is a scale of 10 to one. I think it's like an eight.

Interviewer: Uh-huh. Yes, I'll ask similar questions again. Why did you answer 8?

Speaker: I answered 8 because I am not completely satisfied. But I'm not dissatisfied either. It's more like this... Let me say that I think it has shortcomings, because of that. I think those deficiencies correspond to two points.

Interviewer: Why 8 and not 7 or 9?

Speaker: Uh-huh. Maybe it could have been 7. But not 9, not as close as 9. I wonder if 7 would be too low. I feel like an 8 would have been just right for him, I think, in that thing, in that direction. I mean, 7 would be low because it's on my satisfaction scale.

Interviewer: And did your relationship meet your expectations?

Speaker: I mean, again, if we think about it from the very beginning... I don't even remember, I mean, what expectations... I remember that I wanted to be with someone I was going to marry. At that point, when we go back that far, I can say that it might have met my expectations. Does it meet my expectations now? I mean, as I said, it's still a binary expectation, maybe the same parallel in being satisfied. Again, something close to eight points. It's somewhere like it doesn't quite meet them. But I can't say it doesn't meet them at all.

Interviewer: We're actually about to finish our meeting. I would like to summarize what we talked about in the last hour. You are [26-30] years old. You talked about a relationship that started with a flirtation, meeting your partner in the same community and then becoming friends. In the back, sorry. You mentioned that for you what makes a relationship of high quality is the importance of love, communication, a relationship that progresses without boredom and with respect for private space. And the qualities that make it low quality are that there can be limitations and mixed signals. You mentioned that you feel safe in this relationship. And you mentioned that it is actually important for you to feel safe in a relationship and that one should be able to maintain one's integrity. You talked about the importance of these things. You mentioned that love is a biological process and a momentary short-term thing that needs to be a little careful. And it is not very important in a relationship. You shared that you think we should be a little cautious about it. You mentioned that you understand that your partner loves you through verbal expressions, behaviors and thoughts, thinking about you. And you talked about the importance of maintaining the relationship by spending time together, doing different

activities together, as well as communication. Well, you talked to your partner about the fact that this relationship necessarily changes you, that you are very young at first and that you have grown up together. And you mentioned again that you often feel safe, as I said. Were these things true? Is there anything you would like to add?

Speaker: Well, I think it sums up today, an hour. Yeah, that's about right. Well, I don't think I have anything to add.

Interviewer: Finally, I would like to ask how comfortable you felt while asking these questions.

Speaker: I was quite comfortable

Interviewer: I'm so glad you're comfortable. Yes, thank you very much again. Now, before we finish, I would like to talk to you about how we will handle the data. As a research project, we want to be as ethically transparent as possible. And that's why we think that you are the one who should decide which data sharing option you want to choose. There are two options, obviously. The first option is to share some parts of the transcript of our interview. None of these transcripts will contain any information that can identify you. So that our interview transcript can be read by other researchers in a de-identified way. The second option is if it is convenient for you, if you don't mind and if you want to be a little more daring. Sharing our entire interview transcript by removing sensitive and identifying details, that is, by anonymizing it. In this option, there is a slim chance that someone who knows you well will be able to piece together the details from the interview transcript and narrow it down to who you are among your colleagues. Again, I would like to point out that this option will also be anonymized. Which of these would you prefer?

Speaker: I prefer the latter.

Interviewer: Again, thank you very much for participating in this study. Well, I would like you to know that this study was conducted in the Philippines, Brazil, the Netherlands, France and the USA. We actually have one last request from you. For this study to be successful, could you suggest two close people in your life as candidates if they are suitable for you? We will ask them to suggest couples that you don't know. And in this way, we aim to reach as diverse a pool of participants as possible.

Speaker: Uh-huh, let me think.

Interviewer: It's done.

Speaker: Uh-huh, well, we can communicate via [Social Media] then if you want. Thank you very much again.

Interviewer: If there is nothing you want to express in the recording, I stop the recording

Speaker: You can stop it.